

HYDROZOANS

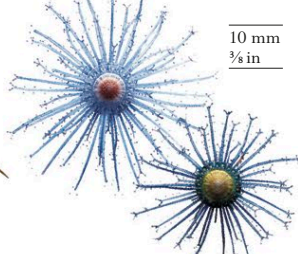
Most animals of the class Hydrozoa live as branching sea-dwelling colonies forming miniature polyp-bearing forests. Some anchor themselves to surfaces by creeping horizontal stems, called stolons. Colonies are supported by a horny translucent sheath and some of the polyps produce sexual medusae. Freshwater hydra lack medusae; instead, sex organs develop directly on solitary polyps.



SNAILFUR

Hydractinia echinata
F: Hydractiniidae

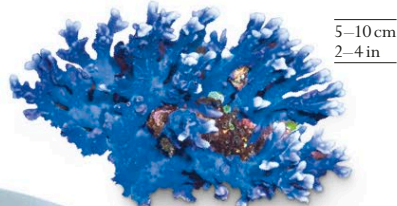
One of a family of colonial spiny hydrozoans, this N.E. Atlantic species grows over the surface of snail shells containing hermit crabs.



BLUE BUTTONS

Porpita porpita
F: Porpitidae

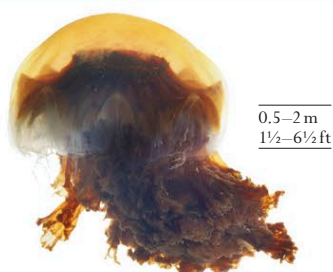
This colonial, jellyfish-like hydrozoan of tropical oceans is sometimes regarded as a highly modified individual polyp.



PURPLE LACE "CORAL" HYDROID

Distichopora violacea
F: Stylasteridae

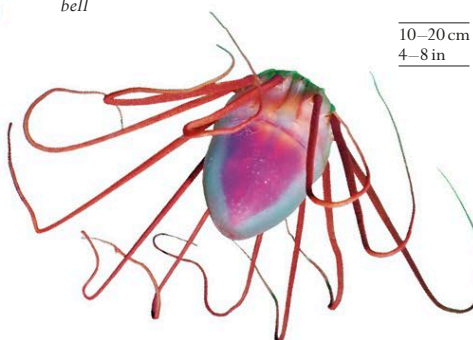
Like some other hydrozoans, colonies of this Indo-Pacific lace coral have polyps specialized for different functions, such as feeding and stinging.



LION'S MANE JELLYFISH

Cyanea capillata
F: Cyaneidae

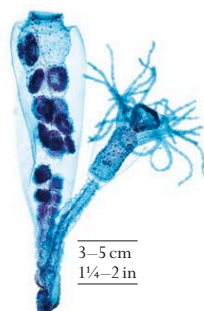
A large species of Arctic waters, this jellyfish has many tentacles arranged in dense groups. It has a powerful sting and its prey includes fish.



DEEP SEA CORONATE JELLYFISH

Periphylla periphylla
F: Periphyllidae

This is one of many little-known deep-water species in a group of jellyfish characterized by a bell with an encircling groove.



COMMON OBELIA

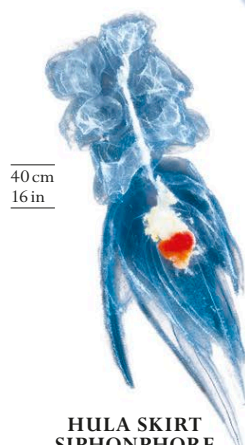
Obelia geniculata
F: Campanulariidae

This is a worldwide hydrozoan, abundant on intertidal seaweeds. It grows in zig-zag colonies of cup-encased polyps that sprout from creeping horizontal stems.

PORTUGUESE MAN OF WAR

Physalia physalis
F: Physaliidae

Resembling a jellyfish, this is really an ocean-going colony of hydrozoans. Stinging tentacles and specialized polyps are suspended from a gas-filled float.



HULA SKIRT SIPHONPHORE

Physophora hydrostatica
F: Physophoridae

This widespread free-floating hydrozoan colony has a smaller float than its relative, the Portuguese man of war, and carries prominent swimming bells.



PINK-HEARTED HYDROID

Tubularia sp.
F: Tubulariidae

Tubularia hydrozoans have polyps on long stems with two whorls of tentacles, one around the polyp base and one around its mouth.

10 mm
3/8 in

3–5 cm
1 1/4–2 in

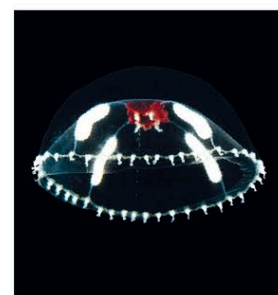


EIGHT-RIBBED HYDROMEDUSA

Melicertum octocostatum
F: Melicertidae

This hydrozoan from the North Atlantic and North Pacific oceans belongs to a family related to those with cup-encased polyps. It is known mainly from medusae.

10 mm
3/8 in



CUP HYDROMEDUSA

Phialella quadrata
F: Phialellidae

Like related *Obelia*, branching colonies of this globally widespread hydrozoan release free-living medusae, which reproduce sexually.

4–6 cm
1 6/16–2 3/16 in



FEATHER HYDROID

Aglaophenia cupressina
F: Aglaopheniidae

Feather hydroids and the closely related sea ferns belong to a group of colonial hydrozoans with cup-encased polyps. This is an Indo-Pacific species.

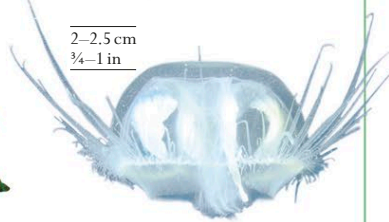


4–15 mm
5/32–1/2 in

COMMON HYDRA

Hydra vulgaris
F: Hydridae

Lacking the medusa stage, hydras have small freshwater polyps that can reproduce asexually by budding. This is a globally widespread cold-water species, shown here in false colour.



2–2.5 cm
3/4–1 in

FRESHWATER JELLYFISH

Craspedacusta sowerbii
F: Olindiidae

Sporadic in freshwater ponds, lakes, and streams worldwide, minute polyps of this animal develop into dominant medusae.



umbrella-like bell

oral arm

gas-filled float

40 cm
16 in

10–50 m
33–165 ft

0.5–2 m
1 1/2–6 1/2 ft

10–20 cm
4–8 in

10–20 cm
4–8 in

40–50 cm
16–20 in